

The Battle of Gaugamela, 331BC

After Issus, Darius raised another army. According to Arrian, Quintus Curtius Rufus and Plutarch, this army had between 40 000 and 200 000 cavalry and 200 000 and 1 000 000 infantry, 200 chariots and 15 elephants. Darius even cleared a plain to give a completely flat arena for the chariots. He wanted to surround Alexander's army with his superior numbers of cavalry.

To meet this threat Alexander once again showed his tactical genius by taking careful precautions. His army had approximately 7000 cavalry and 43 000 infantry. He ordered it to advance obliquely to the right across the battlefield. By doing this Alexander hoped to edge the two armies out of the cleared ground. Darius' army at first followed suit, but then Darius sent Bessus' cavalry to ride around the Macedonian right wing and stop them from continuing this movement. Bessus did so but found that he needed to commit more and more of his troops to the battle at that point. This created a problem in the centre of the Persian army. A gap started to appear in their line.

The Macedonian troops on Alexander's left likewise caused problems for the Persian cavalry on Darius' right wing. Darius launched his scythed chariots in an attempt to break up the Macedonian line in the centre. Macedonian training and discipline, as well as Alexander's careful planning, countered this. The pezetairoi simply stepped aside and created lanes for the chariots to charge down. The light javelinmen and archers then shot them down as they ran past them.

Amid this confusion, with the Persian line weakened, Alexander charged the Companions through the gap created by Bessus' troop movements and once again rode directly at Darius. The pezetairoi and hypaspists also engaged the line, holding it and stopping the Persian infantry from reaching the Companions.

After the defeat of his cavalry bodyguard Darius believed all was lost and again ran, taking with him half of his army. During the engagement a Persian and Indian cavalry force had managed to attack the Macedonian baggage camp but was driven off. Alexander and the

Companions proceeded to deal with the remaining Persian forces.

This battle gave Alexander a third victory over the Persians and virtual control of the Persian Empire. Persian losses were reckoned at 40 000 to 300 000 killed and even more captured with only 100 to 500 Macedonian dead. Alexander and his army had defeated a vastly superior force largely because of clever tactics.

- Copy the diagram below into your book. Draw the battle in six stages and write a paragraph to explain what is happening at each stage of the battle.
- What preparations did Darius make that should have allowed him to win the battle? What went wrong with these plans?
- Imagine that you are Callisthenes, the official Macedonian historian who went with Alexander on the campaign. Describe how Alexander won the Battle of Gaugamela.
- As a journalist, write two headlines for this victory.
- What did the victory at this battle achieve for Alexander?

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